

JONAH PAIN POINT TRANSCRIPT

“Now, I will say, before we get too distracted, now that we've beaten around the bush, no, now that I hope I've set expectations of like how I want you to feel and you can come to me, then I can come to you, it's just a game. There is a pain point I would like to discuss with you. going into the campaign, that I did notice in the one shot, and in my one-on-ones with some other people was partly partly touched on. And that is specifically, and again, could just, I, the only, I only bring this up, and I hope that you will know what I'm talking about and not feel like Michael's so dumb. He doesn't understand that that was because I had a calculator on me. Everyone knows when I have a calculator, I start fiending for death. Um, but specifically, There was, if to bring up, like you mentioned, the, um, the every other feat was was a little just was a little frustrating to you. Totally yet, no. And the, um, there was, there was, uh, I'm just making sure you know what I'm talking about, so you don't feel blindsided, right? There was some frustration there, and there was some frustration with the basic reflex save as well, where the 2 things that I kind of remember. where there was some amount of, I believe you were saying, it's like, I don't know how I, how I was expected to know that. Some things along the line of that, if you recall.

The specific thing was that like, um, of, of like not, I guess what I would, what I would ask is that, and this actually stems from, I played a game with, I'm sharing this with you because, you know, this is a story between me and Gregory, but I'm sharing this with you because I think it's semi-applicable. I played a D&D game where I was at the table with Gregory, and he played a character, Dr. Bones, and he got to the point of the campaign that he just loathed every session. Right? And you could tell the whole time, like he was so frustrated with everything. Gregory just only wears his heart in his sleeve and it may it, I remember thinking in my head at one and I didn't say it, but I remember thinking in my head, I was like, if you're this miserable playing the game, stop coming. Stop making that everyone else's problem. I'm not saying you're at that intensity, but it was the whole thing of like, when you're frustrated with the game, other people notice, right? And it does it affects other people too.

And I understand you not, like, again, just new information, right? But what I would ask of you is that when you're introduced to something that doesn't make sense in the moment, there be like a heart of grace, of approaching, of, you know, taking it on its heel, and then if there's something where it doesn't quite make sense, just come into me after the game. Again, like you were like, hey, just now, like in this conversation, I don't get the diag, like the over diagonal thing. I'm sharing that video with you, we can talk about it more. And there comes a point where if you just can't get behind it, I'm not that attached to that rule. Like there may be a world where we're just like, whatever, get rid of it. Um, but just there was like, again, that's tingling towards that whole thing of, How it seems. Part of it, again, gets to the sort of like the respect thing of like, you don't trust me to be running the game in a way, like, well. And I know I know what you're saying, but just in the sense of like, if I'm like, hey,

this works this way, you know, that's, and it comes off as like, that's stupid. don't get that. That feels a little bit in the moment of like, you think I'm stupid. and I don't get that. Not saying that's what you're saying, just that's the whole thing. We're bouncing back and forth and can feel a little bit like that. Um,

Yeah, this is a team of them almost done as well. No, 100%. I totally get there's an amount of like emotions or emotions, right? That was just the sole thing, that like, I noticed there was throughout the session, there was some grumbling. that, also, other players noticed. And I just want to talk to you about it. I wanted to get your thoughts about it. You kind of addressed it a little bit. You thought the diagonal was really stupid, and that's part of why you were grumbling about it. And so getting your thoughts of like why that happened and how we can hopefully have that be like less of a thing, right? Where, you know, where it's it's not something where you have a like, oh, well, that's OP or that's dumb. And I mean, like, again, you can totally think those thoughts. It's just when you're in the heat of the game and you're just seething there at your seat, crossing your own. I'm exaggerating this because I like to make jokes of this. I hope you do not take this in a hurtful way. You're seething in your seat, crossing your arms, furling your brow, thinking like this is dumb. No, I don't know how anyone can see how this is okay. I promise you that everyone else at the table sees that and in the same way that I noticed everyone get really uncomfortable when I yelled at my dad, we all kind of feel the like, okay, Jonah's upset about how this is running. And it's not like we can do anything.

Um, and I know that is, there's an amount of, is something is going to make you mad. It going to make you mad. But just having the perspective of like grace and like trusting it and verifying later, that might help avoid it being frustrating in the moment. of like, I don't totally get this, but I'm gonna trust that this system works the way it's supposed to, or that Michael's making an okay call. I'll just talk to him about it later. Does that mean sense?

Yeah, no. Um, I'm curious for your thoughts. No, and I appreciate you bringing this up. I trust it wasn't, you know, killing of the fun. No, I wouldn't say so. Um, that's that's that's crazy. But I already mentioned, I think, in this kind of another aspect where the bluntness is a, not just a thing I kind of do is per personality. It's a, you know, not the good to, to me, but it's a reinforce habit. unfortunately. And it's more of, like what we're doing. I basically doing what we're doing now, but worse and in the moment. where it's where I don't, when I, and I kind of have this thing where I will say something and half the time forget I just said it. I barely remember mentioning anything about Reflexive. I do remember the feet part. I remember that, because I, you know, brought it myself. But the whole, I couldn't tell you what exactly said. I think I mentioned, I think it says something about, um, like a nuance with more reflex means.

Yeah, there was some, if I recall correctly, and stop me if at any point, I'm talking about the wrong thing. All right. You were using an ability, and you're like, it doesn't say anything about half damage here. And I went, is it a basic reflex save? And you went, yeah, yeah, it says basic here. I was like, so basics, similar to traits in Pathfinder, basic is something that modifies the save. So it's like a

framework that applies, meaning crit success, nothing happened, success, half damage, failure. Um, full damage, critical failure, uh, double damage. And you frowned at the time or like, I don't know how I could have been expected to know that. What was at least what I had heard?

Um, which again, the whole point of the session was I knew there were things you weren't going to know, and I was there to help facilitate knowledge. And so that was kind of like my point of like coming to it with grace, if rather than being like, I don't know how I was expecting. No one was expecting you to know that. I guess it's the way to put it. And so viewing it through that lens led you to be a little upset about it rather than be like, oh, okay, so that's how that works. If that makes any sense.

Yeah, no, that's fair. I want you to know, like, I love you. This is not me trying to be like, you're so dumb. I don't want you to feel bad. I just wanted to address this because there were some people that were like, Jonah was kind of grumbly, and that it was similar to the way it makes me feel, it's like, oh, you don't trust what I'm saying. It's the same thing of like, why is he having a problem about this, I guess, is the kind of thing.

Yeah, um, I think I know that was definitely a knee jerk reaction and I don't remember saying it until you brought it up. I, I'm realizing because, um, again, it's not the excuse or anything. No, we're just talking about it. You know how, and none of this is gonna be. You know how, Greg will say, like, bear in mind for a bit, and that's just like a kind of a transition area. Now that this is specifically a transitional phrase, but it's more like, how would I say? It's, um... It was like a... I think it's the best way to say it. It was knee jerk defense. Um, when there wasn't even accusation. And I think that as fatigue was definitely a part of that. 100%.

Because I don't think I made that. I'm pretty certain I made that or that's a very infrequent occurrence at this point. Please grab it for a wrong, but I... No, no, no. I definitely, been the 1st time I think I've had that kind of slip in a little bit, but, um, I think, like, the closest thing to thought I had with that was more, um, like, I guess the strategic sense of like, oh, I thought I was going to be able to do more than I could have on the failure. So I felt like I was missing because I was spending 2 actions. And it did feel like those, those savor sex situations hurt more. Uh, for sure. Um, but, um, yeah, that's the closest thing to a thought. It's not like in any way we were in danger or that there was any major issue that...

Yeah, yeah. And again, like, I don't think it's bad for you to have thoughts about the game. That'd be insane for me to say. Again, and part of this is also me just coming to you of like, what can I do, right? Like, you know, I don't want to accidentally make you feel like you need to be defensive. And you know, some of this is like, this is something that I've noticed that happens. And when it does happen, not that it happens regularly, but it does, it affects people. It affects you too. I mean, like, I'm sure you don't love feeling defensive, right? And again, the whole point is we're all trying to have fun. So I'm just, I noticed it, and I'm asking you about it, of like, is there something I can do? there something you can do? Right? Um, and I mean, that's just my thought.

I think if this helps, you already have in the sense that that wouldn't have happened if I was being intentional. I think I could say that very confidently. Okay. Um, because if we heard Vermont, I don't believe there was another instance of that. That was the only time. Again, not like a keeping score. Oh, I saw only one time I was I was gruffly. But, uh, no, I think that that's just a lack of intentionality. And the knee regression of, oh, I wasn't 2 actions, but that sucks. And it and it turned and it translated into some mug though.”

[...]

“Again, like, I don't think it's bad for you to have thoughts about the game. Thatd be insane for me to say. Again, and part of this is also me just coming to you of like, what can I do, right? Like, you know, I don't want to accidentally make you feel like you need to be defensive.”

[...]

“But, yeah, no, I'm, I think that, yeah, I think that's, uh, familiarity definitely hell. Um, intentionality with responses will, uh, And now that we're kind of both looking for it, I feel that that automatically helps.

No, and the others are looking for too. I will do my best to, um, especially for the 1st few sessions, which I know that's when things are going to be the newest. I'll keep a lookout for like, is General Grumbling? Don't I okay. It's the weird thing I don't want you to feel like you're walking on eggshells. You're not. This is not like a, we're lynching Jonah.

I actually just had a idea because I kind of, I made a joke about this already. Okay. where I will kind of like notice I'm saying things like that and I'll go grumble, grum, grumble. Like, if you were to like, say, come on, come on, come on, or stuff like that, I would find it both funny and also a, um, a reminder that I did it. you know, that's, um, I think I was sometimes able to like catch it, kind of make it wholesome. Um, or try to.

Okay. But, again, not to encourage to say stuff like that in order for you, for for the opportunity for me to go crumble, crumble. But I think, again, once it's brought to my attention, I don't. I don't agree with my grumbling. I guess if that makes sense, right?

So like if I'm intentional about, oh, I know, I'm probably going to say not. And that was that was that was part of this conversation was like, I wanted to see where your head was at. If you were like, I feel perfectly justified in being mad at the table. I'd be like, okay, I don't know how compatible that is with the kind of game I want to have. But at the same time, being human is the expectation, right? Like I don't expect you to sit down and start embodying Jesus. I know I can't, right? I will do my best to be the most Christ-like I can be, but I know I'm not. Um, So, yeah, no, again.

As long, this is just something I wanted to bring up so that we can think about it. Because I am excited to have you at the game. I'm excited about your character. I am, I'm excited about you doing your warbles and your, um, manipulating your body to look like random, random nonsense to to build.”

[...]

“And yeah, just a little. Yeah, and what I'd say is, again, this is the whole of, like, I wanted to make sure that we were addressing it in case it comes up again, rather than it being something where, like, um, again, I sit on it for 14 years, and at the midnight, I'm like, how dare you, Jonah? Do you know that for 14 years you've been grumbling every time I say to make a saving throw? Did you know that? And you're over here like, why didn't you bring this up the 1st time? I would have vulture, or that actually, there would have been a nice information.

No, I have never experienced that ever. With anyone that's related to you. No, there's been no experience within, like, any gives off those, this issue. But, um, But no, the most important thing to me, sorry. I really were just talking. I'm sorry. I blamed disquity latency. It's just that, like, we're both acknowledging it and we would like it to not be that in that sense of, like, so that way that means if it comes up, we work on it. That's what I that's what I wanted to hear. That makes any sense.

Yeah, no, I think that's the conclusion of, like, new stuff, new thing, who is, what is, uh, and, uh, knee jerk reactions being more intense than I, just not, just the one making New York reactions. Like, again, if we're just if we're being intentional about it, it's not even going to be a thing.”

I brought up a specific behavior I had noticed during the one-shot: when Jonah encountered a rule or mechanical outcome that surprised or frustrated him, some of his immediate comments and visible reactions came across as grumbling or dismissiveness. I cited the diagonal movement discussion and, more concretely, the basic Reflex save incident. In that incident, Jonah had spent two actions expecting an effect to work one way, learned afterward that the word “basic” carried additional save rules, and responded along the lines of “I don’t know how I was expected to know that.”

My concern was mainly about the table effect. Other players could see when Jonah was frustrated, and comments such as something being “dumb,” “broken,” or impossible to have known could make the atmosphere briefly adversarial. I also explained that, from my position as GM, an immediate negative reaction to a ruling can sometimes feel like a lack of trust in my adjudication even when Jonah does not mean it that way.

I asked him to approach unfamiliar rulings with some initial grace: get the ruling, ask whatever clarification he actually needs, continue playing, and bring a deeper objection to me afterward if it still bothers him. I also made clear that this did not mean he was forbidden from disliking a rule or criticizing the game.

Jonah accepted the criticism. He identified the basic-save response as a “knee jerk defense” and said there had not actually been an accusation for him to defend himself against. He thought fatigue contributed, but did not use that as a reason the behavior should continue. He explained that his actual internal reaction had been much smaller: essentially, “I spent two actions on that and got less out of it than I thought; that sucks.” His outward wording and expression communicated considerably more anger than he was actually feeling.

He also identified a broader habit behind it. He is used to commenting immediately on games: calling things “broken,” complaining about surprising mechanics, and verbalizing the first reaction that enters his head. Sometimes he does not even remember making the comment afterward. He recognized that this habit can communicate something stronger than he intends.

The practical solutions Jonah proposed were to be more intentional before responding, give himself a moment before saying the first thing that comes to mind, and use clarifying questions when he is confused. He thought simply knowing that me and him were both watching for the behavior would already make a large difference.

I agreed to help from the GM side. One thing I identified was reducing the situation where several players simultaneously explain rules to somebody who is already trying to process unfamiliar mechanics. Jonah specifically acknowledged that this could contribute to his defensiveness.

Jonah then proposed the light “grumble, grumble” cue himself. If I notice him slipping into the habit, he is comfortable with me lightly calling attention to it. He expects that to make him notice the behavior without requiring a serious interruption to play.

The final agreement was essentially: Jonah does not believe the grumbling is something he is entitled to do at the table, I do not expect him to suppress ordinary human frustration, and both of us will address it early if it starts happening again. That acknowledgement was the result I told him I'd had been looking for.